



Pixel to Platform: Redesigning Atlas Games' Website as a Strategic Design Tool

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Table Of Contents

Table Of Contents.....	1
List Of Figures.....	2
Design Strategy.....	1
Project Definition.....	1
Problem Statement.....	2
Strategic Framework.....	3
Core Design Strategy:.....	3
Design Tools and Approaches.....	3
Measurable Objectives.....	3
Alignment and Research Approach.....	4
User Research.....	4
Competitive Analysis.....	4
Technical Feasibility Study.....	5
Alignment with Brand Identity and Business Vision.....	5
Risk Management Planning.....	6
Main Risk: User-Centred Risks.....	8
Risk:.....	8
Mitigation Strategy:.....	8
Reference List.....	9

List Of Figures

Figure 1: Who Is Atlas Games (Rall, 2025)

Figure 2: Atlas Games Golden Circle (Rall, 2025)

Figure 3: Atlas Games Colour Pallet (Rall, 2025)

Figure 4: Atlas Games Target Audience (Rall, 2025)

Figure 5: All of Atlas Games Possible Risks (Rall, 2025)

Design Strategy

Project Definition



Figure 1: Who Is Atlas Games (Rall, 2025)



Figure 2:Atlas Games Golden Circle (Rall, 2025)

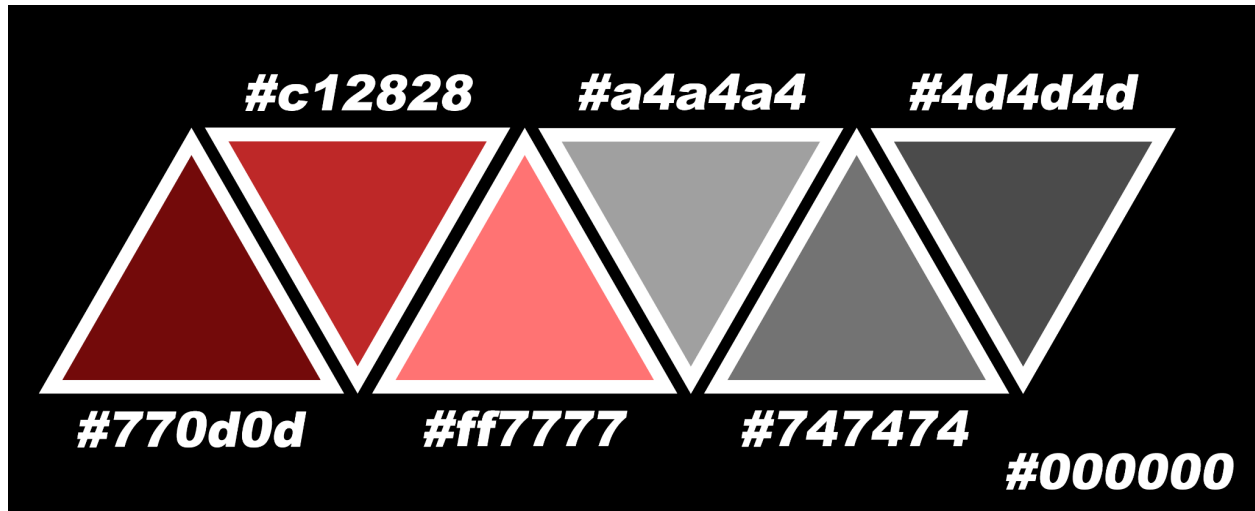


Figure 3: Atlas Games Colour Pallet (Rall, 2025)



Figure 4: Atlas Games Target Audience (Rall, 2025)

Problem Statement

Currently, Atlas Games (formerly known as Fruckets) suffers from fragmented digital representation, with a disjointed Wix website, an isolated Itch.io profile, and zero cohesive brand strategy. This inconsistency undermines trust, professional perception, and future scalability. Van Zyl (2023) highlights that early-stage South African design start-ups often lack the infrastructure to communicate value effectively, which limits their access to funding, press, and collaboration opportunities. With rebranding to Atlas Games, there is now an urgent need for a unified design strategy that elevates the brand visually, structurally, and narratively across digital platforms, thereby laying the groundwork for long-term growth.

Strategic Framework

Core Design Strategy:

This redesign adopts a User-Centred Design (UCD) approach, guided by Minimalist Aesthetics, each selected to reflect Atlas Games' values and constraints.

User-Centred Design ensures that all decisions, layout, navigation, and structure are grounded in user expectations and habits. This is crucial for an audience that includes casual players, funders, and journalists, who each require intuitive access to different types of content. As Stone (2010a) explains, strategic thinking in design must begin with understanding both the user journey and the brand's purpose.

Minimalist Design helps simplify the website and reduce cognitive overload. Given the studio's limited resources and content, a minimalist approach ensures that every visual and interactive element serves a purpose. It supports clarity, faster load times, and an uncluttered interface, key to building early trust in a low-attention digital environment.

The combination of these two strategies allows Atlas Games to express who they are, what they stand for, and why it matters, while also delivering a seamless user experience.

Design Tools and Approaches

- Use of grid-based responsive design for mobile-first accessibility.
- Integration with Itch.io via embedded game widgets or buttons.
- Branded sections for: About Us, Games, Team, Press, and Contact.
- Visual system built around red (energy), black (professionalism), and grey (neutrality/balance) (see Figure 3).

Measurable Objectives

Tracking success is essential to validate the impact of the redesign. According to Lockwood (2007), the true value of design lies not only in creativity but in its measurable contribution to business performance.

Objective	KPI	Timeline
Launch new brand-aligned website	Fully published and functional	Within 3 weeks

Improve user engagement	Bounce rate below 40%	Within 2 months post-launch
Grow visibility	200% increase in average monthly site visits	Within 90 days
Build an early community	100+ newsletter signups or Discord joins	Within 6 weeks
Increase game reach	50+ new downloads of Cancer Crusher	Within 30 days

Each of these objectives is tied directly to user needs and business goals. By designing with measurable outcomes in mind, the studio can evaluate progress and refine its efforts post-launch.

Alignment and Research Approach

To ensure that the website redesign is not only functional but strategically sound, the following research and alignment methods will be used.

User Research

The team will gather informal feedback from games previously released by this studio before it was rebranded to Atlas Games. The original studio, Fruckets, published a series of video game titles in the Variety Games genre. One such example was Cancer Crusher - a game spreading awareness of the warning signs around certain forms of testicular cancer. The team of Atlas Games will gather informal feedback from Cancer Crusher players and peers in the South African indie game space. This will include lightweight testing of early prototypes, asking users to complete basic tasks and providing feedback on ease of use and emotional resonance. Stone (2010a) stresses the importance of gathering early-stage insight from real users to validate assumptions and reduce design misalignment.

Competitive Analysis

Successful indie studios such as Donderbos Games, Southgame Studio and Clockwork Acorn will be used as benchmarking references. These competitors offer valuable insight into how small-to-mid-sized studios use their websites to tell a brand story, showcase products, and build community. These examples will inform the layout and tone of Atlas Games' site.

Technical Feasibility Study

Given the team's limited technical background and resources, the website will be developed using the GitHub Pages System. This choice ensures faster deployment, ease of maintenance, and responsive design on all devices. This practical consideration reflects the team's real-world constraints, a key aspect of Van Zyl's (2023) model for early-stage South African design enterprises.

Alignment with Brand Identity and Business Vision

The proposed website design aligns directly with Atlas Games' mission: to tell meaningful, emotional stories through interactive media while uplifting underrepresented voices in game development.

Visual elements such as the Atlas logo, the red-black-grey colour palette, and clean typography will embody the studio's professional aspirations while maintaining a strong indie personality. Storytelling will be embedded throughout, not only in the games but in how the brand speaks to its users.

As Liedtka (2010) points out, design is most impactful when it operates as a bridge between user understanding and strategic intent. This project is a practical example of that principle: ensuring the website reflects both who Atlas Games is and what it wants to become.

Risk Management Planning

As Atlas Games undergoes its rebranding and redesign process, it faces several strategic, technical, and ethical risks that may impact the success of its new digital presence. The following section identifies five key risk categories relevant to the project and proposes realistic, actionable mitigation strategies, grounded in design management principles and entrepreneurial research.

5 Of the possible Atlas Games Risks INFOGRAPHIC

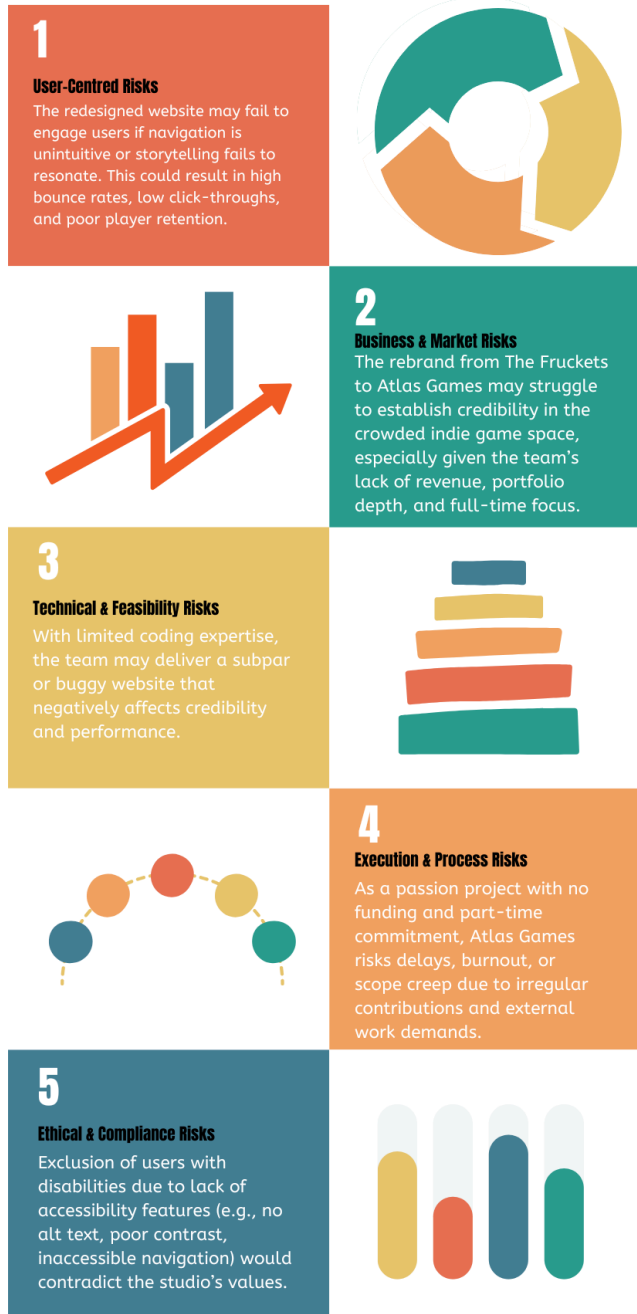


Figure 5: All of Atlas Games Possible Risks (Rall, 2025)

Main Risk: User-Centred Risks

Risk:

The redesigned website may fail to engage users if navigation is unintuitive, storytelling lacks resonance, or visual design does not reflect user expectations. A poor user experience can result in high bounce rates, low click-throughs, and limited retention of both casual players and professional stakeholders such as funders or reviewers. If users encounter excessive friction while exploring the site, such as hidden navigation paths, inconsistent layout patterns, or confusing content hierarchy, they may abandon the website before meaningfully engaging with Atlas Games' story or projects. Furthermore, without a properly configured domain name system and Search Engine Optimisation (SEO) practices, the site risks not being indexed by Google. This would severely reduce discoverability, making it difficult for users to locate the website organically, thereby limiting brand growth and visibility in a competitive indie gaming market. In addition, mobile users, who represent a significant share of the target audience, may disengage quickly if the site lacks responsiveness, fast load speeds, or accessible design features. These risks collectively pose a serious barrier to building trust, community, and long-term brand loyalty.

Mitigation Strategy:

To address these challenges, lightweight yet iterative user testing will be conducted, including informal walkthroughs, task-based trials, and structured feedback surveys with peers, early players, and members of the South African indie gaming community. By adopting a User-Centred Design framework (Stone, 2010a), the team will ensure that design decisions remain grounded in actual user behaviour rather than internal assumptions. This involves prioritising mobile-first layouts, clear navigation pathways, and emotionally resonant storytelling that reflects the studio's identity and values. Accessibility testing will be embedded into the process, ensuring that users across different devices and internet speeds can interact with the site seamlessly.

From a strategic perspective, this aligns with Liedtka's (2010) argument that understanding user behaviour is not only a design concern but a driver of organisational success. Incorporating SEO fundamentals, such as metadata, descriptive URLs, and optimised site architecture, will help mitigate discoverability risks and ensure proper indexing by Google. By combining usability testing, responsive technical design, and narrative alignment, the project aims to reduce bounce rates, foster meaningful engagement, and create a professional digital presence capable of supporting both community-building and long-term business objectives.

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